

First-year homeowner maintenance checklist

Use what applies. Follow equipment instructions and local guidance.

Your first week

- ☐ **Gather the inspection report and closing documents.**
Make a short follow-up list of unresolved items. Give urgent repairs priority over routine upkeep.
- ☐ **Locate essential home controls.**
Record the main water shutoff and electrical panel locations. Ask a qualified professional to explain anything unfamiliar; locating a control is not an instruction to operate it.
- ☐ **Check smoke alarms.**
Use the test button as directed by the manufacturer. Note manufacture dates; USFA recommends replacing smoke alarms at 10 years. Ask your local fire department about placement or accessibility needs.
- ☐ **Start an appliance record.**
Write down model and serial numbers, purchase or installation dates, manual links, and where the receipts are stored. Leave unknown dates blank.
- ☐ **Save useful contacts.**
Keep your utility contact numbers, a plumber, and heating/cooling service information with your home records.

Your first month

- ☐ **Find the HVAC filter instructions.**
Record the correct size and type. Inspect it monthly; clean or replace it according to the equipment and filter instructions and its condition.
- ☐ **Look for visible plumbing leaks.**
Check accessible areas beneath sinks and around toilets and appliances for drips or moisture. Record problems and arrange repair.
- ☐ **Read the maintenance sections of your manuals.**
Add only the tasks that apply to your appliances and systems. Use manufacturer guidance for intervals.
- ☐ **Review warranty paperwork.**
Copy the stated coverage dates, covered parts, service contact, and any registration requirements. A reminder date is not proof of coverage.
- ☐ **Create a short maintenance calendar.**
Start with alarm tests, filter inspections, seasonal planning, and any service already due. Set dates you can realistically keep.

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Each month

- ☐ **Test smoke alarms.**
Follow each alarm manufacturer's test procedure. Check carbon monoxide alarms on their own recommended schedule.
- ☐ **Inspect the HVAC filter.**
Check condition and record whether it needs cleaning or replacement under the manufacturer's instructions.
- ☐ **Check for new drips or moisture.**
Look at accessible plumbing and appliance connections. Arrange help for persistent leaks or unexplained dampness.
- ☐ **Record completed work.**
Save the actual date, a short note, and any receipt. Reschedule missed work deliberately rather than marking it done.

As seasons change

- ☐ **Plan heating and cooling service.**
ENERGY STAR recommends annual pre-season contractor check-ups: cooling before hot weather and heating before cold weather.
- ☐ **Review the outside of the home from the ground.**
Note visible drainage, gutter, or roof concerns for a qualified professional. Do not climb onto a roof to complete this list.
- ☐ **Prepare climate-specific systems.**
Follow local utility and manufacturer guidance for freeze protection, irrigation, storms, or other conditions that apply.
- ☐ **Review your records before the year ends.**
Check upcoming warranty dates, update service contacts, and export a backup of digital home records.

Next task / date: _____

Planning prompts, not a home inspection or repair procedure. Use qualified help for electrical, gas, structural, and work-at-height tasks.

Sources checked September 18, 2026: ENERGY STAR maintenance checklist; U.S. Fire Administration smoke alarms; EPA WaterSense finding leaks. Links are in the online guide.